# Dead Men's Fingers

## By Don Nigro

**OPHELIA:** The fact is, I am, and have always been, much too intelligent for my own good-it was I think my downfall, in fact, that I could think, and think much more deeply and efficiently than that poor spoiled delinquent . Hamlet ever could, but there was a kind of blindness all about me, they could not see it, would not see it, for along with my intelligence came a desire to be thought good, to be kind to those around me, to give my father what pleasure I could, to keep my brother Laertes, who was in his own way even stupider than my dear moronic father, as serene from moment to moment as could be expected - my tragedy was that while I loved all these people I knew how stupid they were, and could do nothing about it.

## INTRODUCTION

*Shakespeare's Ophelia – A weak woman who descends into madness? Obedient daughter? Subservient?*

*In Don Nigro's interpretation as presented in Dead Men's Fingers – we are allowed into Ophelia's innermost thoughts about love, family, life and ultimately her own death. And Nigro's Ophelia is anything but weak, obedient and subservient.*

*Dead Men's Fingers by Don Nigro*

**OPHELIA:** It's very strange, not what I had expected it to be. I don't know what I expected, exactly, but this definitely isn't it. And yet it seems, in the end, to have been more or less inevitable that this is what it should have turned out, finally, to be like. Remembrance. Death is remembrance. As of a performance. As of a play completed. In a dark, empty theatre. Do you know what I keep thinking of?

We're very small, playing in the garden, under the crab apple tree, Hamlet, Laertes and me. Hamlet suggests that we play Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden. Hamlet's games, even then, always seemed to take the form of elaborate stage plays, with himself as director, god

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and star. First, he says, Laertes and I must take off all our clothing. I have some reservations about this, but in the end we always do everything Hamlet tells us to. Now, says Hamlet, Laertes is Adam and Ophelia is Eve. But she's my sister, protests Laertes. So was Eve Adam's sister, says Hamlet. They had the same father, didn't they? Oh, says Laertes. He was never very bright. Now, says Hamlet, I am the serpent, and Laertes must go away and name some animals. Which animals? asks Laertes. I can't say, answers Hamlet reasonably, until you've named them, can I? So Laertes goes off sulking to find some animals to name. We have no animals in Denmark, he says, kicking the dirt and bruising the knuckles of his toes.

When Laertes is gone, Hamlet turns to me and says, Hello, Eve. I'm the serpent. I don't like serpents. I say. Oh, but you must like me, he says, I'm a very nice serpent. I've come to bring you knowledge. What knowledge? I ask, very suspicious, and beginning to get cold, standing there naked in the garden. Knowledge, says Hamlet, of good and evil. And then he pulls me towards him, and he kisses me, and puts his tongue in my mouth. What on earth are you doing? I ask, pulling away. I'm being a serpent, he says. Serpent tongues do that. Not in my mouth, they don't, I say. Tell me about good and evil. Well, he says-but before he can tell me, my father catches us, and I get a good whipping. Hamlet, of course, gets off with a tongue lashing from the old King, who is rather amused by the whole thing. This by the way was the pattern of our youth, Hamlet would get other people in trouble and then somehow evade responsibility for it.

I always regretted not getting from him the answer about good and evil, it was an important question for me. But my misfortune was that, although I thought much about such things, I tended to keep them to myself, and thus I perpetuated the myth that I was beautiful but not very bright. Gradually I began to go insane. It was not, as some have thought, a direct result of my father's murder. Oh, no, no, such things only give us an excuse to manifest the madness that is already within us. No, the madness began in my childhood, it was the result of my attempts to solve the mystery of the knowledge of the tree of good and evil- I could make no sense of it. For everything around me seemed such a terrible admixture of things

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partly lovely and partly horrid.

Hamlet was kind and funny and utterly charming and yet cruel and selfish and cold and full of hatred. The Queen was beautiful and kind and gentle and considerate and also blind and foolish and vain and weak. Claudius was ambitious and deceitful and a murderer, but he was also rather more intelligent than the others, well read, a gifted painter, a person who could discuss botany or point out the constellations or recall the name of a poor tailor he had met in the street twelve years ago and ask him about his three children and his wife with the glass eye. He was in many ways a better king than the brother he murdered. And he loved Gertrude with all his heart. He felt that Hamlet was mentally ill and very dangerous, and he was right on both counts. And Laertes loved me with great apparent devotion, but Hamlet's remark about eating a crocodile at my shabby burial service was, I'm sorry to say, much to the point, for in fact I believe Laertes loved the idea of having a sister more than he loved me in particular - in reality I believe his actual attachment to me was more sexual than anything else, he desired me, physically desired me, at least from the day Hamlet cast us as Adam and Eve in the garden.

And then there is Father, my dear father, who often spoke words of great wisdom without, unfortunately, listening to what he was saying, who would give wise counsel mixed with absolute rubbish and never be able to tell the difference, whose love for me I found genuine and touching at one moment, only to be in the next moment utterly forgotten in a storm of peevishness.

They were all such jumbles of contradictions, they made me so angry and confused, I could not deal with one of them in a consecutive way, each time I walked into a room and found one, I had to hold back, to wait and see what face they had put on this day, when what I wanted was to run at them and desperately put my arms around them and hug them, yes, even Claudius or the old dead King, hug them and tell them how hopelessly I loved them, and how fervently I hated them, but it was no use, I could do neither, it would have fallen dead upon their ears.

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Now, Yorick, however, Yorick, I sometimes felt, did understand this, or at least some of this, and me, or at least some of me, and much else, perhaps, but Yorick was always drunk, and then he went and fell off the battlements in a stupor one dark night and broke his neck and my heart, and there I was, still a child, and with no one to talk to for the rest of my life. It was one manifestation of my madness, I think, early on, that I would from time to time speak with Yorick, after a fashion, subsequent to his swan dive from the south tower. He would appear to me and I would speak with him, although I could never quite make out what he was saying to me, as he seemed to be speaking under water with a great wad of hay in his mouth. At any rate it was thus to Yorick's probably imaginary ghost that I confided the fact-and only to him-that I was carrying a child in my body.

In a way it had all been Yorick's fault, for we had, as small children, once spied upon him engaging in a spirited act of intercourse with a young serving maid, what was her name? Gretel?

Lord, lord, we couldn't take our eyes off them, at first, but then Hamlet did a characteristic thing, he turned away in disgust, but not me, not me, I watched to the bitter end, in utter fascination. The girl lay there naked like an old painting, she was really quite beautiful, and she touched her face to his shoulder so easily, as if it had all been carefully choreographed, as if God had taught her how to do this before he allowed her to be born, and I wondered if I also knew, if I had her secret knowledge, and if Hamlet had his as well.

And so it was that, some years later, with him suffering, suffering, for the death of his father the old King, and the infidelity of his mother the Queen, and the treachery of his uncle the new King, him so sad, so sad and troubled, and I was going past his chamber, one night I couldn't sleep, and I heard him crying, crying like a baby, him, who I'd never seen cry in his life, not for any amount of pain, not when he broke his arm or when Yorick died or when his father died, even, but then, months after, there, in his room, crying and crying, as if his heart would break, and so I crept in, in the dark, it was very dark and cool in his chamber, and I took off my nightgown, let it slip to the floor, and slipped quietly into his bed, he was

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so cold, and I knew how, just as Gretel the servant girl had known, God had taught me how and I had forgotten until it became necessary, and there we made the beast together, Hamlet and I, him desperate, me serene, very serene, with the ghost of the old King watching us in the dark, his two red eyes glowing in the blackness, it was after this that he turned on me and began to hate me, what do you think that nunnery business was really all about, you fools?

It was his guilt, his horrible stupid guilt for it, and his anger at me for my compassion, and because I felt no guilt at all, so I could not very well tell him, could I, that I was carrying his child, and so, in the course of time, after he had conveniently murdered my poor idiot of a father, there was nothing left, I could tell, nothing left but to let the madness come gushing out like a freshwater spring, and take a swim in it.

There was a willow grown aslant a brook. Actually I think it was a pond, the Queen was not a stickler for precise definitions, even in her better days. And so I did. Billowed up. Feeling the cool water creep up my legs and thighs and into my body like a snake to caress my child inside, I sang, I sang, and then, and then, gradually, up came the water over my shoulders and up my neck, I shuddered and slid under, so gently, so gently under the cold water, and the dumb Queen watched and did nothing. I had entered into a deeper reality.

Do you know why poor Hamlet loved the players so? Because they made alternative realities. He was not fond of the reality he'd been cast in by time or chance or the great maniacal playwright deity. He was a fool. Much more than Yorick was. I, on the other hand, played out my part to the end. Am I to be succour, or am I to be innocence? This is the heroine's dilemma. But I of course was both and neither.

It's so sad he couldn't appreciate the beauty of it. The beauty in the entire pattern of it. The whole labyrinth as it is traced. The entire play one is cast in, so to speak. I suppose his play was about him not wanting to be in his play. But I had my own play, and it turned out rather well, actually, when seen from the larger point of view that madness or deity affords. That's

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the beauty of having the privilege of playing a character in one of the myriad of interconnected playlets in the vast dramatic epic cycle which is God's megadrama. You get to be at once vividly and inevitably the person you are cast as, but also, if you are, like me, also rather more clever than the usual player, you get, in another part of your mind, to sense the beauty of the moving action of the play that you are a character in, and of the wondrous intricacy of that play's relation to the larger set of plays with which it is simultaneously being performed. How terrible it is, and how complex and strangely beautiful, as I was saying only the other century to Yorick's ghost, with whom I and my dead child live quite happily as spectators in the dark auditorium, as all ghosts are.

And so, there I am, you see. A bit of rue. A bit of rosemary. Some pansies for thoughts. Death is remembrance, a kind of quiet theatre. And there, in the pond, hung all about, I can still see them, dipping into the water, all about me, mysterious and lovely, I see dead men's fingers.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Don Nigro***
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***ISBN: 978-0573621055***
***Publisher: Samuel French, Inc.***
***Date (Month/Year): 1989***

## AWARD HISTORY

***2003 National Qualifier***
***2007 National Qualifier***
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